

If your pet insurance partially denied your rehab claim...

A fellow pet parent shares what worked

If your dog or cat is receiving veterinary rehabilitation and your insurer has partially denied a claim — paying for some of the session but carving out a portion as “*massage*” or “*alternative and holistic treatment*” — you’re not alone, and you have options.

THE MOST IMPORTANT THING TO KNOW

If your policy expressly covers *physical therapy* and *laser therapy* (often listed under a Rehabilitation or Supplemental Benefit), your integrated rehab session is almost certainly covered. The partial denial often **doesn’t hold up against the policy text** when challenged with a careful written appeal. Many carriers reverse it when pushed back.

YOU MIGHT BE IN THIS SITUATION IF...

- Your insurer pays **most** of each rehab session but carves out 20–30%
- The denied portion is labeled “**massage**” or “**alternative and holistic treatment**”
- The same denial repeats week after week, even though no separate massage was performed
- Your invoice from the rehab practice is a **single line item** (e.g., “Rehab + UWTM”) with no separate massage charge

What you can do

1 Read your policy carefully

Pay attention to the *Rehabilitation / Physical Therapy* coverage section, the definition of “*Alternative and Holistic Treatment*,” and any *proration* provision. The full policy is on your member portal.

2 Look at your EOB closely

Identify the exact denied amount, the exclusion section cited, and how it was calculated. Carriers often apply a flat percentage carveout that isn’t tied to anything specific in your records.

3 File a written formal appeal

Most policies have an appeals process. Cite the specific policy sections that *cover* the services performed and explain how the denial misclassifies them. *See the QR code on the back for the actual appeal letter I used, as a reference example.*

4 Ask your rehab vet for a supporting letter

A letter on practice letterhead, attesting that what’s documented as “manual therapy” is the canonical components of physical rehab (not a separable “massage”), substantially strengthens the appeal. *The QR code on the back also includes the supporting letter my rehab vet provided.*

Continued on the other side → *What happened in my case, what to do if your first appeal is denied, why this matters, and how to find help.*

A real example: Gatsby's story



Gatsby

MY CASE

Three weekly claims. Three identical denials. One successful appeal.

Gatsby has been with me since 2014. In April 2026, an MRI confirmed Degenerative Myelopathy and disc protrusions in his lower spine. We started weekly rehab at Skylos: underwater treadmill, laser, stretching, joint mobilization, under a board-certified rehab veterinarian.

The first two claims were paid in full. Then my insurer carved out a flat 25% of each subsequent session as “massage” — three identical carveouts in a row. I filed a formal appeal citing the policy sections that cover the services performed. The insurer reversed all three denials.

A PERSONAL NOTE — WHY I'M SHARING THIS

When our pets get seriously sick, it is one of the hardest things to go through with someone we love. Veterinary teams help us through these vulnerable moments as much as they can — and it is painful that some market practices extract small amounts of money from families in this position. I share this with no personal gain. I share it because I want the experience Gatsby and I are going through to mean something a little more than just our own story — to let the love we share reach a little further than we ever possibly can on our own.

If your first appeal is denied...

5 Escalate to the Independent Third-Party Veterinarian (ITPV)

Most policies provide for second-level review by an outside veterinarian on questions of “*medical nuance*.” Whether manual contact is separable from the covered rehab modalities is exactly that kind of question.

6 File a complaint with your state insurance regulator

Even if your appeal succeeds, regulators care about *patterns*. A short complaint contributes to market-conduct oversight that, over time, can shift carrier behavior across the industry. It's free and doesn't require a lawyer.

WHERE TO FIND HELP

Maryland Insurance Administration: 1-800-492-6116 · insurance.maryland.gov

Washington Office of the Insurance Commissioner: 1-800-562-6900 · insurance.wa.gov

Other states: Search “[your state] insurance commissioner complaint”

NAIC consumer directory: naic.org/consumer.htm



MY LETTERS AS A REFERENCE

Scan to view the redacted appeal letter
& vet supporting letter

Shared by Dr. Yuxin Zhu, a fellow pet parent — one pet parent to another.

Informational only, not legal or insurance advice. Every policy and situation is different. For questions about your specific policy or claim, contact your insurer, your state insurance regulator, or an attorney. If you received this pamphlet from a veterinary practice or another organization, they are sharing it as a courtesy resource and do not endorse or oppose any specific carrier or position; their role is your pet's clinical care.